Research plans and literature reviews

Lesson 8, 90 minutes. Combining tree-ring evidence

Learning objectives

Separate evidence for dates, environment and causes.

Interpret agreement and disagreement among sources.

Develop a question and a plan or literature review.

Three applications and a shared procedure

Application	Main focus	Shared checks
Dendroarchaeology	Objects, buildings, activity	Records, dating, comparisons, limits
Dendroecology	Trees, stands, disturbance	Records, dating, comparisons, limits
Dendroclimatology	Regional, seasonal climate	Records, dating, comparisons, limits

R30 Historic England

R52 Yonenobu & Eckstein (2006)

Observation, dating and interpretation

Observation: directly measured or inspected features.

Dating: placement by crossdating and calendar anchoring.

Interpretation: inference about cutting, disturbance, climate or activity.

Wood and archaeological time

Ring formation — **Felling** — **Processing / use** — **Deposition**

Reuse and repair can separate timber and building dates.

Check the evidence connecting these stages.

Conceptual stages, not measured dates for a particular object.

Linking climate and history

Coinciding changes can motivate a causal hypothesis.

Examine food, water, land use, institutions and other mediating processes.

Match region, season and temporal resolution.

R52 Yonenobu & Eckstein (2006)

Case: wooden containers and dated wooden slips

Maeda and colleagues (2024) compare Nara wooden containers and wooden slips.

Tree-ring dates are compared with written dates.

Read how different sources constrain feature chronology.

R55 Maeda et al. (2024)

Comparing outer-ring and written dates

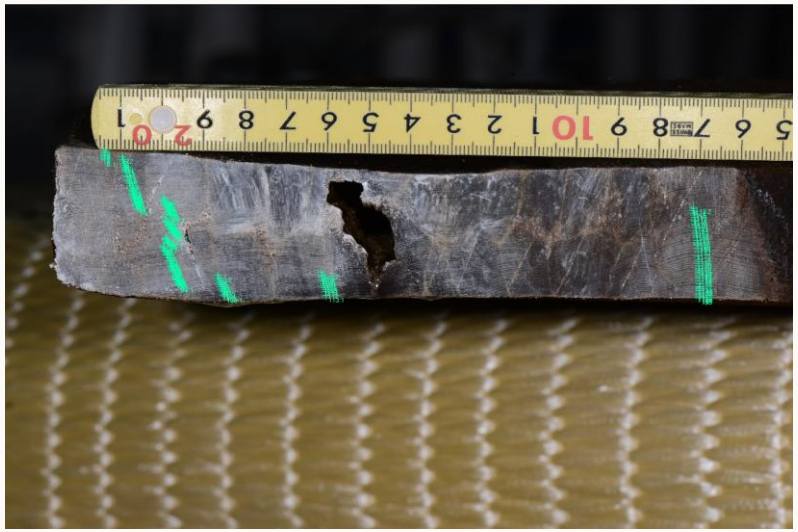
What event does the written year describe?

What outer wood is preserved in the ring-dated object?

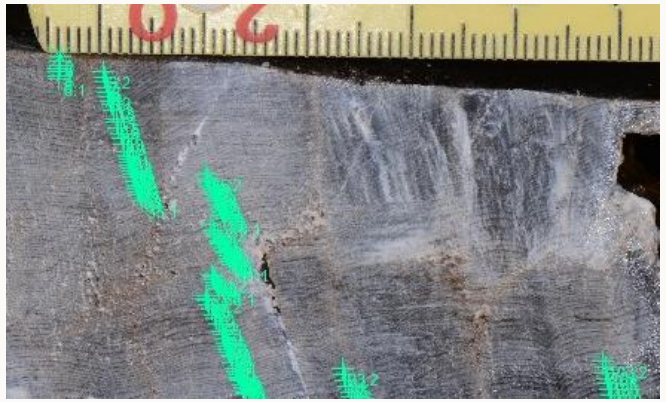
Examine association, duration of use and redeposition.

From an excavated sample to its data

Whole image



Detail cropped from left side



Sample 29ho018

Short marks indicate measurement positions and ring boundaries.

Use the sample ID to connect the image with the numeric record.

Check the source records for species and calendar dates.

Source: Nabunken, 29ho018

CC BY 4.0

An ecological view of growth changes

Suppression may involve climate, insects or competition.

Combine scars, recruitment, mortality and management records.

Examine comparison trees and survivorship bias.

R35 Nowacki & Abrams (1997)

R45 Walker et al. (2014)

The scope of a climate reconstruction

State region, season, climate variable and units.

Check calibration, verification and response stability.

Test the links from local climate to broader social change.

R52 Yonenobu & Eckstein (2006)

Exercise A: interpret three timber dates

All examples are fictional. A building record mentions 1210.

Timber	Last preserved ring	Bark	Location
A	1187	Absent	Part 1
B	1199	Present	Part 2
C	1213	Absent	Part 3

8 minutes: claims, limits and additional evidence.

Synthetic teaching data / schematic, not empirical results.

Exercise A: the limits of the conclusion

A: timber use after formation of the 1187 ring; felling unresolved.

B: the 1199 ring formed; inspect season and interval before use.

C: wood formed through 1213; reassess its relation to the 1210 record.

Synthetic teaching data / schematic, not empirical results.

Sources of uncertainty

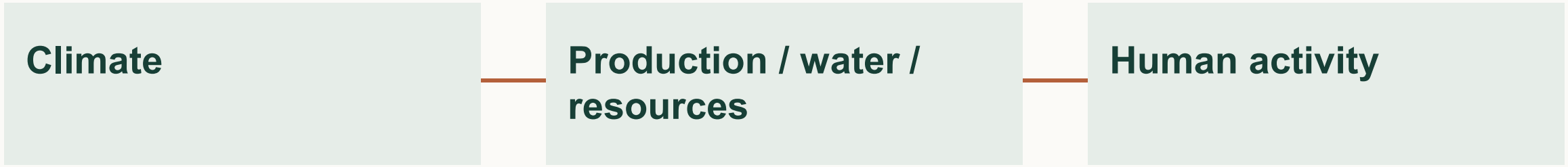
Stage	Questions to check
Measurement / dating	Boundaries, units, dating evidence
Preservation / sampling	Missing outer wood, biased samples
Interpretation	Post-felling intervals, alternative causes

R30 Historic England

R52 Yonenobu & Eckstein (2006)

Diagramming a causal hypothesis

Show proposed processes connecting climate, trees, production and activity.



Consider management, land use, institutions and other pathways.

Arrows indicate hypotheses, not proven causal effects.

Conceptual diagram. Connections are hypotheses to test.

R52 Yonenobu & Eckstein (2006)

Making a question specific

Specify place, period and material.

State competing hypotheses and predicted observations.

Identify evidence that could change the conclusion.

Planning sources and sampling

Check source location, preservation and access conditions.

Plan trees, sites, comparisons and sampling positions.

Prepare alternatives if the preferred material is unavailable.

Matching questions to methods

Calendar dating needs crossdating and an anchored reference.

Disturbance studies combine growth, injuries, populations and comparisons.

Climate estimation needs instrumental calibration and independent testing.

Tracing papers, reports and datasets

Move from the abstract to methods, materials, figures and limits.

Record dataset version, identifiers and the subset used.

Distinguish primary reports from introductory or secondary accounts.

R55 Maeda et al. (2024)

R56 Nabunken (2024)

Presenting figures, data and sources

Make plots with clear axes, units and sample depth.

Distinguish measurements, synthetic data and schematics.

Check the applicable conditions and credits for external figures.

Exercise B: develop a plan or review

State the question, sources, comparisons and limits of your plan or review.

Item	What to include
Question and target	Place, period, competing explanations
Sources and approach	Methods or literature comparison
Limits and further evidence	Alternatives, observations that change the claim

8 minutes: draft 5, discuss 2, revise 1.

Reviewing plans or reviews

Does the evidence address the question?

Are comparisons and independent checks or sources included?

Are alternatives and limits of the evidence considered?

Final report and assessment

Research plan or review: 2–4 A4 pages, 3+ references; figures allowed.

Criterion	What to show
Question	Define the scope and purpose
Sources, methods and comparison	Support sources; explain method or compare studies
Limits, figures and writing	Address alternatives, citation and clarity

Course grade: report only. See the separate rubric.

Assessment details: separate rubric

Conclusions and next checks

State the conclusion supported by the available evidence.

Identify remaining alternatives and uncertainty.

Name one further observation that could change the conclusion.

Keeping records for reanalysis

Preserve identifiers, original measurements, units and missing values.

Track the relationship among processing, figures, text and versions.

Clarify supplied materials and release scope in collaborative work.

Sources for continued learning

Use bilingual terms to search papers and data.

Connect Nabunken records, tree-ring databases and primary papers.

Continue testing explanations against observed material.

Final reflection

How do you distinguish a ring date from an event date?

Can you compare two explanations for one observation?

What evidence could change your plan or review?

Tree rings, environment and historical questions

Record observations, verify dates and compare explanations.

Move among specimens, data and literature.

Present a question together with the limits of its answer.